

THE EL NIÑO SEASON PREP LIST

A Historic Winter Is Coming. Here's How To Be Ready.

Forecasters are calling this El Niño potentially the strongest on record. That doesn't mean panic, it means prep, and this is everything you actually need, not just "have some food and water on hand."

>90%	75%	Jan–Mar
VERY STRONG EL NIÑO	ODDS IT'S HISTORIC	PEAK RAIN WINDOW
this fall & winter	strongest since 1950	builds Nov–Dec, tapers by Apr

HZ
HOUSE OF ZONSHINE

What's Actually Happening

Here's the real read, not just the scary headline — and what it means specifically if you're near Eaton or Palisades.

01

The Forecast

- NOAA's own Sept 10 diagnostic puts this at **>90% odds** of a "very strong" El Niño this fall and winter
- 75% odds it becomes the strongest event on record since 1950 — LA County's own briefings are calling it historic
- The actual wet signal **builds through November and December** as the storm track shifts south, then **peaks January through March**, sharpest flood and mudslide risk in January and February, easing off by April

HISTORIC

02

Worth Knowing

- A strong ocean signal doesn't guarantee LA actually gets soaked
- **The rain you've already felt this fall wasn't El Niño.** Tropical Storm Rachel in October and Hurricane Marie's remnants in September were separate tropical systems passing through. The El Niño pattern itself hasn't started yet
- 2015-16 was the strongest El Niño signal ever measured, and downtown LA still finished *below* average that year
- Real, well-forecast risk worth taking seriously — not a guaranteed disaster

THE HONEST PART

03

If You're Near Eaton Or Palisades

- Both burn scars are still inside their ~2-year window where the soil stays water-repellent
- USGS puts Palisades-area canyons at **60-80% debris-flow odds** under a real storm; Eaton rates **"high"**
- The trigger is small: about a quarter inch of rain in 15 minutes, an ordinary rate

READ THIS ONE TWICE

FROM JULIA

I'm not trying to scare anyone into a bunker mentality here. I just know from being in these neighborhoods every week that the people who fare best in a real storm aren't the ones who panicked, they're the ones who did the boring stuff early. Gutters, sandbags, a flashlight that actually has batteries in it.

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THE FULL CHECKLIST

Everything you do.
Grouped the way you actually tackle it.

The One Everyone Misses

Property & Insurance

- [ ] Clear gutters, downspouts, and storm drains, and make sure water runs away from the foundation, not toward it
- [ ] Trim dead or vulnerable branches near the house, and secure outdoor furniture against high wind
- [ ] **Up to 25 free sandbags per household** at any neighborhood LAFD fire station, year-round
  Call first, they genuinely run out once a storm's in the news. LA County runs a separate program for unincorporated areas.
- [ ] **Flood insurance takes 30+ days to activate** — can't buy it storm week
- [ ] Repair known roof leaks now, not mid-storm
- [ ] On a hillside lot? Check retaining walls, drainage and soil for cracks or erosion
- [ ] **Flood damage isn't covered by standard homeowners insurance** — it's a separate policy

WATER & FOOD

- [ ] **1 gallon, per person, per day, minimum 3 days.**
  FEMA's real target is 2 weeks if you have the space
- [ ] A manual can opener, plus shelf-stable basics: crackers, peanut butter, canned beans and chicken
- [ ] Got little kids? Skip the health-food guilt trip and pack it like a picnic — whatever they'll actually eat without a fight
- [ ] Canned fruit is worth grabbing too (peaches, pineapple, mandarin oranges)
  Not an everyday food, but real nutrition matters when you're stuck inside with nothing to do
- [ ] **Unopened fridge: ~4 hrs. Full freezer: ~48 hrs, ~24 if half full.**
  Source: USDA — every door-open resets the clock

LIGHT, POWER & SIGNAL

- [ ] **Headlamps over candles** — open flame in a power-out house is a bad call, especially with burn-scar fire risk still fresh
- [ ] A battery or crank lantern per room, plus a charged power bank for phones
- [ ] **Generator: 20 ft from the house,** exhaust away, never in a garage
  Source: CPSC — carbon monoxide too close is a real, fatal risk
- [ ] Battery-backup CO alarms on every level
- [ ] A battery or crank NOAA weather radio, plus offline maps downloaded before, not during

MEDICAL, CASH & PETS

- [ ] 7–14 days of any prescription, refilled ahead, plus a backup power plan for medical devices
- [ ] Cash in small bills
  Card readers and ATMs need power too
- [ ] Copies of ID, insurance, and key documents, waterproofed or backed up digitally
- [ ] Gas tank at least half full through storm season
  Pumps run on electricity
- [ ] Pet food, water, meds, and a carrier staged and ready

NEW — CITY & COUNTY TOOLS

Stay In The Loop

All free, all already paid for with your tax dollars, most people just don't know they exist.

- [ ] **NotifyLA** — City of LA emergency alerts by text, call or email
  notifyla.org
- [ ] **Know Your Zone** — look up your home's evacuation zone before you ever need it
  protect.genasys.com
- [ ] **Report a flooded street or clogged drain** — MyLA311 app, or call, 24 hours
  1-800-773-2489
- [ ] **Alert LA County** — same idea, county-wide
  lacounty.gov/emergency
- [ ] **LADWP outage alerts** — text or email when your power goes
  Sign up through your LADWP account
- [ ] **Check your FEMA flood zone** — matters if a lender ever requires flood insurance
  msc.fema.gov

The Week Before A Storm Hits

SECTION 04

- [ ] Charge every device and power bank you own
- [ ] Fill water containers and top off the gas tank
- [ ] Move valuables off the ground floor if you're flood-prone
- [ ] Know your evacuation route if you're below a burn scar

IF YOU ONLY REMEMBER THREE THINGS

01

INSURANCE

Flood coverage is separate from homeowners and takes 30+ days to kick in. Check it today.

02

BURN SCARS

A quarter inch of rain in 15 minutes is all it takes on fresh burn scar. Know your route now.

03

POWER OUTAGE

Fridge: ~4 hours. Freezer: ~48 hours. Keep both closed as long as you can.

FROM JULIA

However this winter goes, you don't have to figure it out alone. Storm prep, insurance questions, whether your specific street has ever flooded before you bought there, this is the kind of thing I talk through with clients all year, not just when the forecast gets scary. Reach out any time.

Sources: NOAA Climate Prediction Center (Sept 10, 2026) · Ready LA County · USGS Landslide Hazards Program · USDA FoodSafety.gov · Ready.gov/FEMA · U.S. CPSC · LAFD · LA County Public Works · NotifyLA · Alert LA County · Genasys Know Your Zone · LADWP · LA Sanitation & Environment · FEMA Flood Map Service Center

Julia Zonshine
Compass | DRE 02246696
@houseofzonshine · @rsrrealestate
818-859-0762

I've Got You

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